Chapter 16

Task K: Receive Emails and Respond with Rich Text

We've now got a fully functioning store, internationalized for global domination, but what if a customer has a problem they can't solve using our site? With Rails, we can easily do what most e-commerce sites do, which is allow customers to email us so we can solve their problem and write them back with a solution.

Hopefully, you've come to expect by now that Rails has us covered. We sent emails to our customers in *Iteration H1: Sending Confirmation Emails*, but Rails includes a powerful way to *receive* emails called Action Mailbox.[74] We'll learn how that works in this chapter. We'll also learn how to create richly formatted text in our replies by using a rich-text editing system included with Rails called Action Text.[75]

Both Action Text and Action Mailbox rely on another Rails library called Active Storage. Active Storage is an abstraction around cloud storage systems like Amazon's S3. Both incoming emails and rich-text attachments are stored in the cloud using Active Storage. We'll explain why as we go.